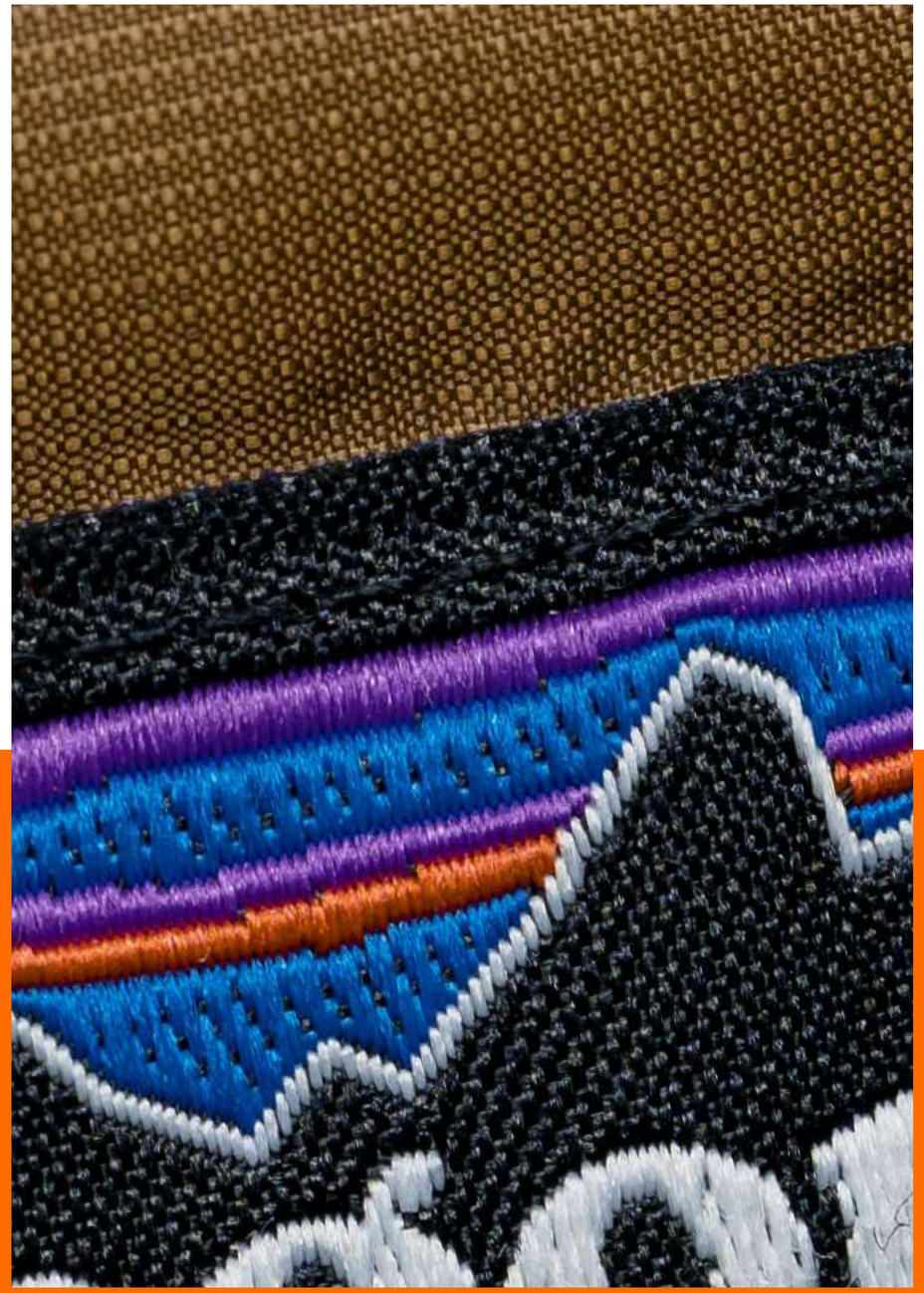


Building a brand like Patagonia.

The blueprint for one of the most successful brands on this planet.

nayture.com



The field of sustainability is in constant flux.

New tools, technologies, practices, and regulations emerge constantly. This variability makes it very challenging for brands to advance and promote sustainability while remaining consistent and authentic, and yet some do with great success.

What we did →

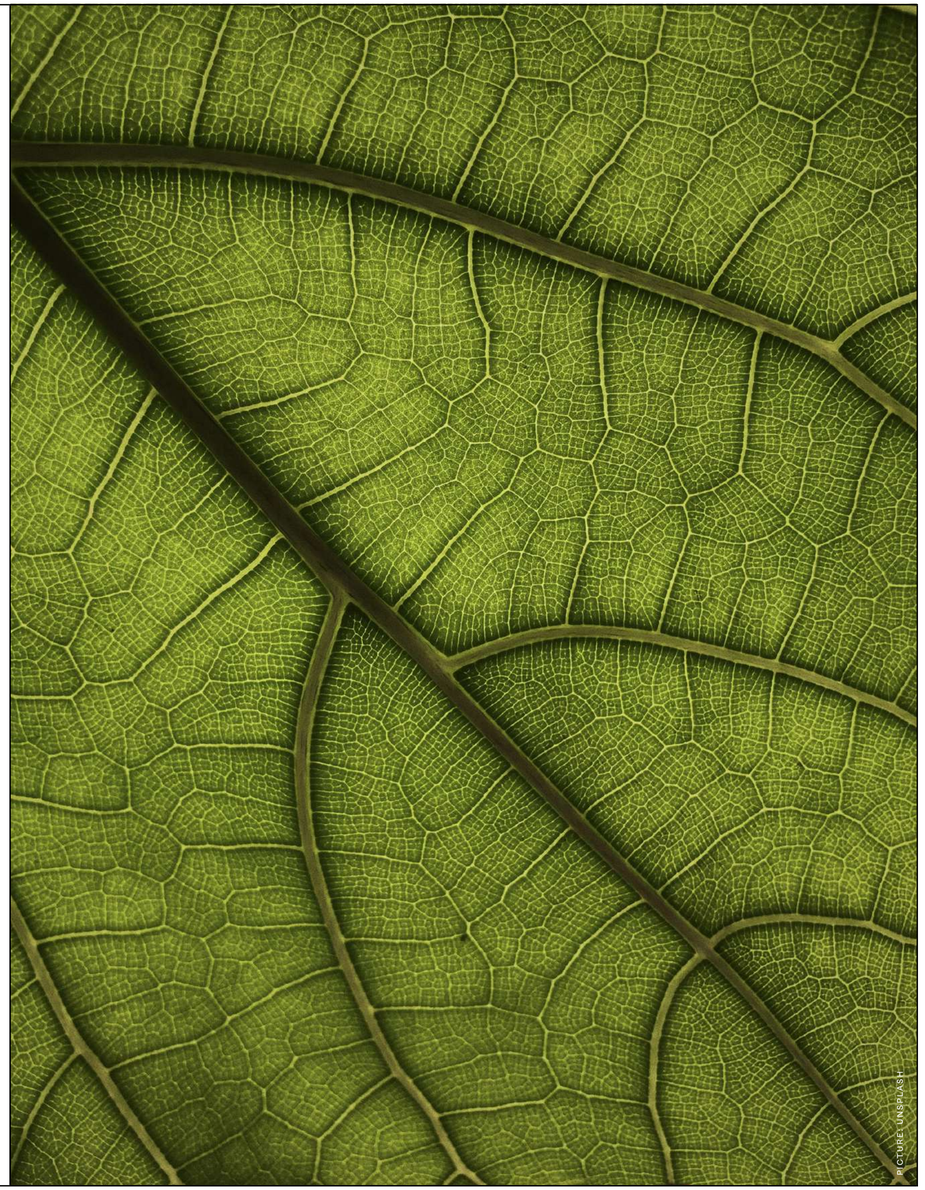
A brand being perceived as »green.«

After analyzing organizations across many sectors, we were able to identify eight fundamental characteristics that are shared by a majority of the most sustainable brands.

Some brands lean more heavily on certain of these characteristics and less on others, but in general, the presence of all eight is a strong, positive predictor of a brand being perceived as »green.«

In this report, we take a look at a global leader in sustainable business – Patagonia – through the lens of our Green Brand Code.

A Nayture Framework →



The Green Brand Code

A NATURE FRAMEWORK



N° 01 First Movers/Pioneers	N° 02 Category Creators	N° 03 Purpose	N° 04 Showing Face
N° 05 Activism	N° 06 Education	N° 07 Premium	N° 08 No Green Talk

N° 01

First Movers/Pioneers

Because these brands challenge the status quo through innovative approaches to market-wide issues, they are always ahead of the pack.

N° 02

Category Creators

Sustainability is most often achieved »outside of the box.« Category creators don’t just use established standards of sustainability – they create their own.

N° 03

Purpose

Strong brands require strong purpose. Green brands get their strength from being purpose-driven, putting people and the environment first.

N° 04

Showing Face

Storytelling is central to successful marketing for all brands, but even more so for green brands, which is why they tend to utilize top-down, public-facing leadership.

N° 05

Activism

For green brands, activism isn’t an ad campaign, it’s central to existing. Genuine effort earns a high score in this category.

N° 06

Education

Brands that pursue sustainability are often advocating for a new way of life, and true advocacy involves providing education.

N° 07

Premium

The most sustainable goods and services often can’t help being of a higher quality – it’s just how they’re made. Premium alone doesn’t signify environmental friendliness, but on the other hand, low quality paired with »sustainable« marketing can be a red flag for greenwashing.

N° 08

No Green Talk

The most sustainable companies don’t talk that often about »sustainability.« Nor do they tend to use green in their corporate identity. Instead, they focus on accountability and transparency.

N° 01

First Movers/Pioneers

pela

N° 02

Category Creators

TONY'S CHOCOLONELY

N° 03

Purpose

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N° 04

Showing Face

THE ORIGINAL OATLY!

N° 05

Activism

10 tentree

N° 06

Education

allbirds

N° 07

Premium

who gives a crap

N° 08

No Green Talk

Unilever


The Green
Brand Code
OF patagonia®
PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Facts Get To Know The Company



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

ESTABLISHED	1973
INDUSTRY	Retail
EMPLOYEES	~ 1,500
TYPE OF ORGANIZATION	Private benefit company
2022 REVENUE ESTIMATE	$1B USD

First Movers The Anti-Consumers.



PICTURE: BELOVED BRANDS.COM

How would you define »apparel brand?« At its most basic, you might say, an apparel brand is just a company that wants people to buy its products.

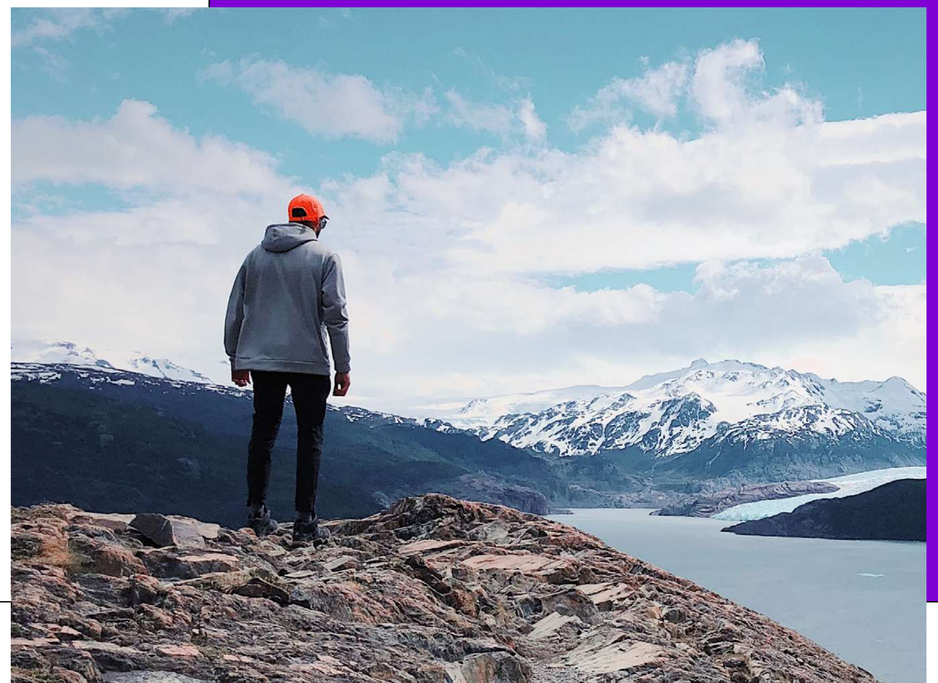
Well, that's kind of what Patagonia is...but not exactly. Patagonia is also one of the only brands – and certainly one of the first – to actively encourage people not to buy its products, as made famous by the company's »Don't Buy This Jacket« advertisement. A central part of Patagonia's ethos is encouraging people to rethink their habits of consumption, whether it's buying second-hand (see the company's Worn Wear shop for used products) or simply deciding to not buy something they don't really need.

Maybe more importantly, Patagonia is a pioneer in the field of corporate activism, having elected since 1985 to donate 1% of all sales to environmental causes, and inspiring more than 5,000 other businesses to take the same pledge.

Still want to buy it? →

Category Creators

Very few brands could grant themselves a nickname as bold as »The Activist Company« without inviting a widespread backlash of greenwashing accusations.



But if the shoe (or fleece-lined vest) fits, we say wear it. Proof that it does indeed fit can be found front and center on the company's main website, where, instead of the obligatory »Sustainability« page you'll see linked to on most consumer goods sites, you'll find a menu labeled »Activism.« Of course, many brands today engage in various forms of activism, but few do it as vigorously and effectively as Patagonia, putting it in a category almost on its own.

More objectively, note that Patagonia is the only consumer goods company to have been given the UN's Champions of the Earth designation, an award that celebrates inspiring and innovative environmental stewardship. Previously, the brand also won the Accenture Strategy Award for Circular Economy Multinational, honoring its ability to drive business growth while simultaneously relying less on scarce resources.

Acting for tomorrow. →



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Purpose

SAVING THE PLANET

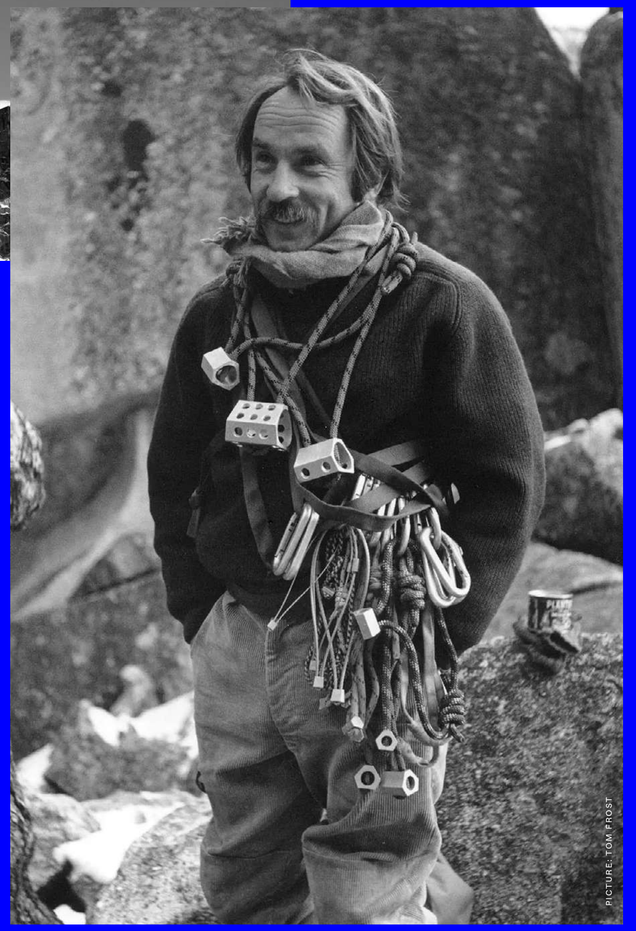
Looking around at the various environmental crises we currently face, from climate change to biodiversity loss, »saving the planet« isn't even a little bit melodramatic. Living up to that phrase is the purpose Patagonia has given itself with the statement »We're in business to save our home planet.«

Naturally, brands that have a catchy mission statement but nothing to back it up don't score well in this category of our framework. Patagonia, however, has no problem walking the walk. In the early days of the brand, the founder kicked its best-selling product to the curb after realizing the environmental damage it caused. Ever since, the company's actions have revolved around core values that include causing no unnecessary harm to the environment and using business to protect nature. Patagonia can't save the planet on its own, but it's sure doing a heck of a job trying.

One has to start →



PICTURE: UNSPLASH



PICTURE: TOM FROST

»What we take, how and what we make, what we waste, is in fact a question of ethics.«

YVON CHOUINARD

Showing Face

YVON CHOUINARD

More than one person has made a mark as a Patagonia representative. Executives including Ryan Gellert and Rose Marcario have been outspoken in discouraging potential customers who don't stand behind the company's values and have helped keep up a strong voice and marketing for the brand. That being said, the most famous face associated with Patagonia is that of its founder, Yvon Chouinard.

Chouinard founded the company, molded it to his vision of sustainability and environmental activism, and continues to influence the direction and perception of the brand. It was Chouinard who committed the company to granting 1% of all sales to environmental causes, Chouinard who was awarded the Sierra Club's John Muir award for distinguished environmental stewardship, and Chouinard who announced the donation of Patagonia's ownership to nonprofit entities – the Patagonia Purpose Trust, valued at $3 billion, and the Holdfast Collective – whose income would be used to combat climate change. »Earth is now our only shareholder,« he famously said, adding that the company went »purpose« instead of going »public.«



PICTURE: LOS ANGELES TIMES

Chouinard may not be as recognizable a figure as, say, Elon Musk or Jeff Bezos, but his visionary leadership and dedication to purpose have been instrumental in building Patagonia's visibility and reputation.

Why did they do this?

»Reusing something instead of immediately discarding it, when done for the right reasons, can be an act of love which expresses our own dignity.«

YVON CHOUINARD



PICTURE: LIFEGATE.COM



Activism

A MOUNTAIN OF ACCOLADES

At this point, we hardly need to demonstrate that Patagonia has a legacy of activism. Instead, we can just highlight some of the many examples.

Check out the timeline. →

1986 –present

Patagonia donated over $100 million to grassroots environmental causes.



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

1996



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Patagonia excluded conventionally-grown cotton from all products in favor of organic cotton (later adding recycled cotton, Cotton in Conversion and Regenerative Organic Certified™ (ROC) Pilot Cotton).

2012



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Patagonia launched Patagonia Provisions, designed to encourage a rethinking of food supply chains and promote organic, regenerative agriculture, became the first California company to sign up for B certification, becoming an official benefit corporation.

2017

Patagonia filed suit against President Donald Trump over his plan to decrease the area of national parkland.



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

2018 –present

Patagonia worked with over 2,000 farmers to establish and promote regenerative agricultural projects in local communities.



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

2021–2022

Patagonia joined the Build Back Fossil Free campaign, asking the U.S. government to block new fossil fuel projects.



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

2022



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Patagonia partnered with the Albanian government to establish a national park protecting the Vjosa, Europe's only remaining wild river. forfeited all nonvoting shares to the Holdfast Collective and all voting shares to the Patagonia Purpose Trust.

Spread the word. →

»If we have any hope of a thriving planet
50 years from now, it demands all of us doing
all we can with the resources we have.
As the business leader I never wanted to be,
I am doing my part. Instead of extracting value
from nature and transforming it into wealth,
we are using the wealth Patagonia creates to
protect the source.«

YVON CHOUINARD

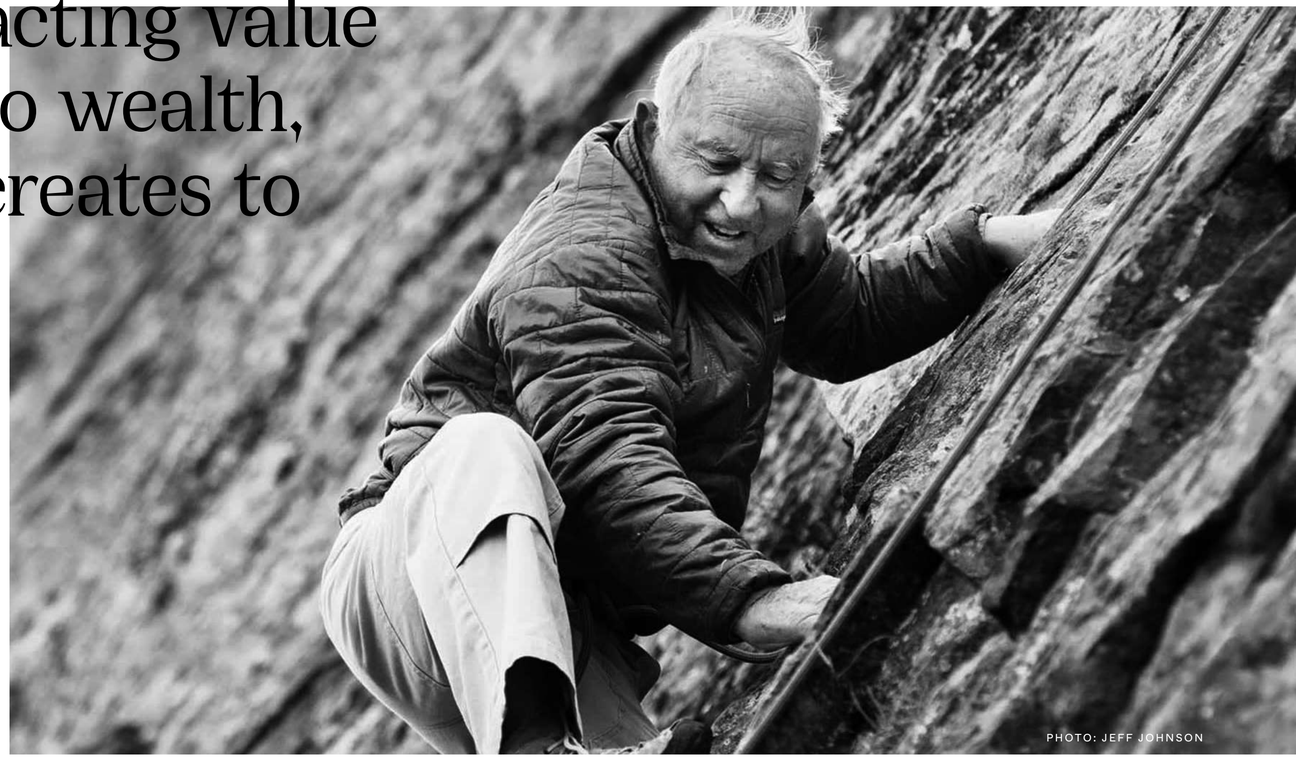


PHOTO: JEFF JOHNSON

Education

Brands that exhibit true »green« qualities almost always encourage people to adopt new ways of thinking or behaving – what to buy, how and where to buy it, and why those choices matter. But for someone to think or act in a certain way, they need to be shown how. Leading by example is great, but we all learn in our own way; Patagonia does a good job of accommodating that by offering numerous educational pathways.

Through its websites and social media channels, the brand encourages people to get involved with its mission of saving the planet, maintaining a steady offering of events, volunteer opportunities, campaigns, and petitions, each of which represent a chance to understand environmental problems – and their potential solutions – more deeply.

And, when Patagonia makes a decision – whether it's to use organic cotton or to engage in political activism – consumers are told why. Likewise, the rationale for its sustainability targets is explained explicitly. The message is always, »We don't want you to just buy into what we're doing, we want you to think about what we're doing – here's why...«

Patagonia Action Works is a platform that connects potential volunteers with local organizations working for environmental causes.



Down to earth. →

»Most of the damage we cause to the planet is the result of our own ignorance.«

YVON CHOUINARD



PICTURE: PATAGONIA.COM

Premium Quality



This category confuses some people at first glance. Is charging a premium price a sure sign that the seller cares about the environment? No. But charging less almost always means offering less – and by less, we're referring to products and services that don't provide long-term usefulness, don't work well, or don't work at all. That can be a dead giveaway that the seller doesn't care about the environment (or their reputation, for that matter).

For brands like Patagonia, the premium price tag is indicative of a few things:

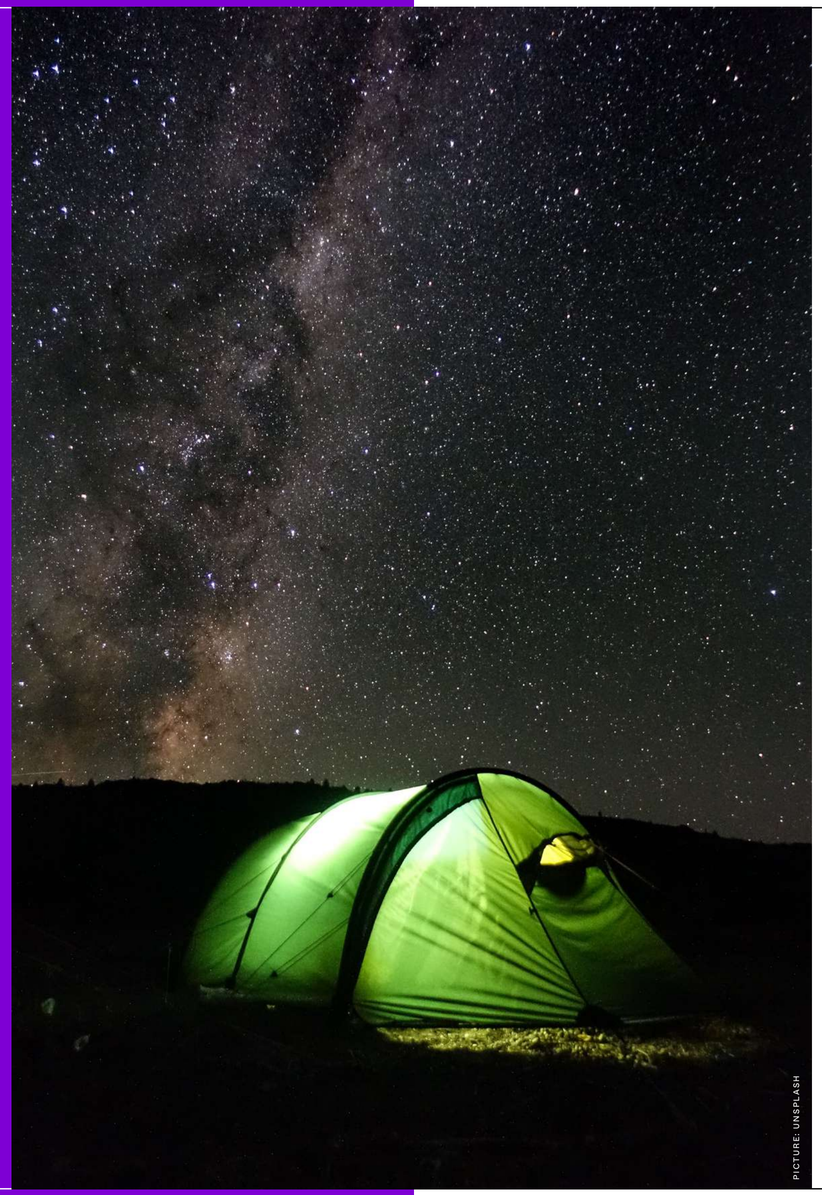
→ Sustainable materials and processes, which cost more than conventional ones
→ Premium quality / designed to last
→ Extensive product development / quality assurance

It costs more to do more, and Patagonia is doing a lot. Its customers are happy to pay more with the knowledge that they're not only getting a great product, they're also supporting the brand's mission and doing the planet a favor in the process.

Patagonia provides a lifetime guarantee on its products, has the largest clothing repair facility in North America, and operates a Worn Wear truck that tours the United States to repair clothing.

No excuses. →

No Green Talk



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

To be clear, Patagonia talks a lot about sustainability, and so do plenty of other brands that score well in this category. What sets them apart is how they talk about it. While it's become the rule for companies to showcase their sustainability targets and green accomplishments, those who speak out about being a part of the problem are still the exception. Patagonia, though, has pushed harder than virtually any other brand to establish a culture of corporate accountability, transparency, and self-criticism.

Browse Patagonia's extensive blog or its various websites and you won't find much fanfare over the awards it's won or the undeniable impact it's had on sustainable business. What you will find is plenty of discussion about the urgency of environmental crises, what needs to be done, and where the brand is still failing to fulfill its purpose. In 2021, Patagonia even published an article in Fortune explaining why the company tries to avoid using the word »sustainable.«

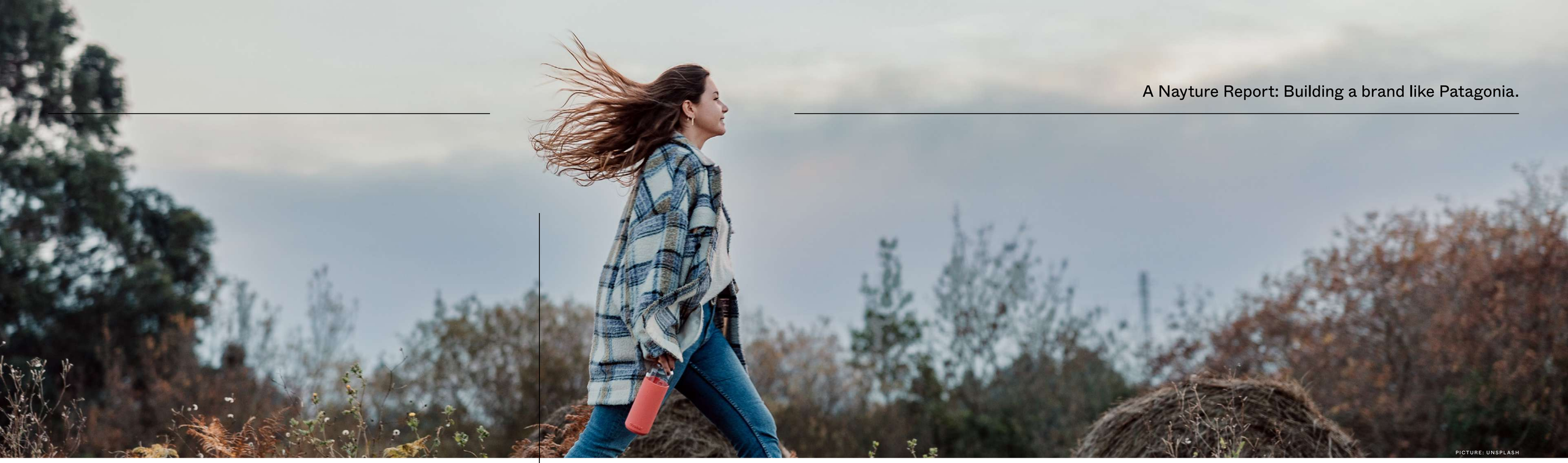
What about people?

»At Patagonia, making a profit is not the goal because the Zen master would say profits happen, when you do everything else right.«

YVON CHOUINARD



PICTURE: UNSPLASH



PICTURE: UNSPLASH

People First.

A BONUS CATEGORY

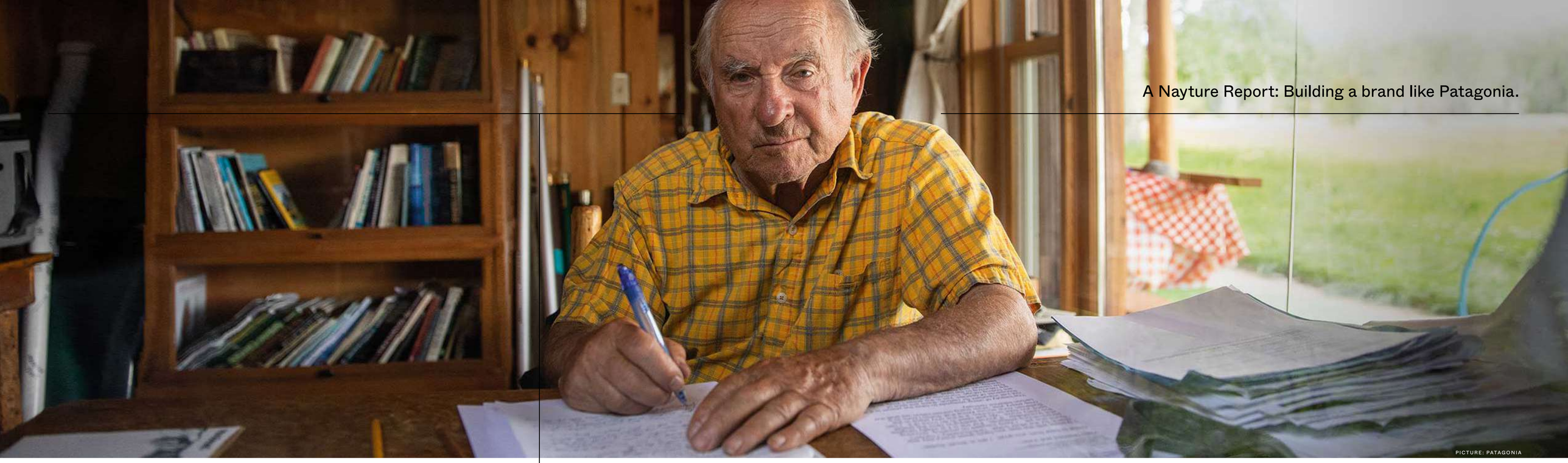
Human-centric culture isn't a requirement for green brands, but there's definitely a positive correlation at work between the two, possibly nowhere more clearly than at Patagonia. Here are a few of the things the brand does as part of its commitment to people:

→ Encourages employees to take up to two paid months per year to volunteer at environmental conservation projects

→ Focuses on fair trade employment practices throughout the supply chain

→ Embraces flexible work hours and has three onsite childcare centers

→ Named by Fortune as one of the 100 Best Companies to Work For



PICTURE: PATAGONIA

Not bound by convention.

A SUMMARY

Along with build the best product, cause no unnecessary harm, and use business to protect nature, Patagonia lists a fourth core value: not bound by convention. The company's success, it says, lies in developing new ways to do things.

Patagonia isn't only developing new ways to create, market, and sell apparel, it's also creating something more encompassing and important – a new way to exist as a company. A way to pursue profits not at the expense of the environment, the climate, employees, or customers.

»Earth is now our only shareholder.«

YVON CHOUINARD

PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Our Services

Green Brand Code Inspiration

Have you ever wondered how brands like Patagonia, Ben & Jerry's, Veja or Oatly became so successful? It all comes down to one magic formula: The Green Brand Code. In the 1 day inspiration workshop we will show blueprints of the most famous green brands in the world, and what principles your brands can use from them.

- Examples of green brands
- Workshop exercises to explore the Green Brand Code for your brand
- Guidelines for brand development

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Do you want to become one of the leading green brands? Let us help you with our Green Brand Code Strategy.

- Competitor analysis
- Exploring positioning areas
- Personalised Green Brand Code
- Brand Strategy
- Touchpoint map
- Content Pillars and formats
- Campaign ideas



10.000,-

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Plugin for your Agency and Consultancy

You are a consultancy or agency and need support with your clients' green communication strategy or green marketing. We are here to help you.

- Use Nayture as your sparring & strategy partner
- We will do the research for you
- We provide inspiring examples of green brands

5.000,-

STARTING AT

Let's talk.

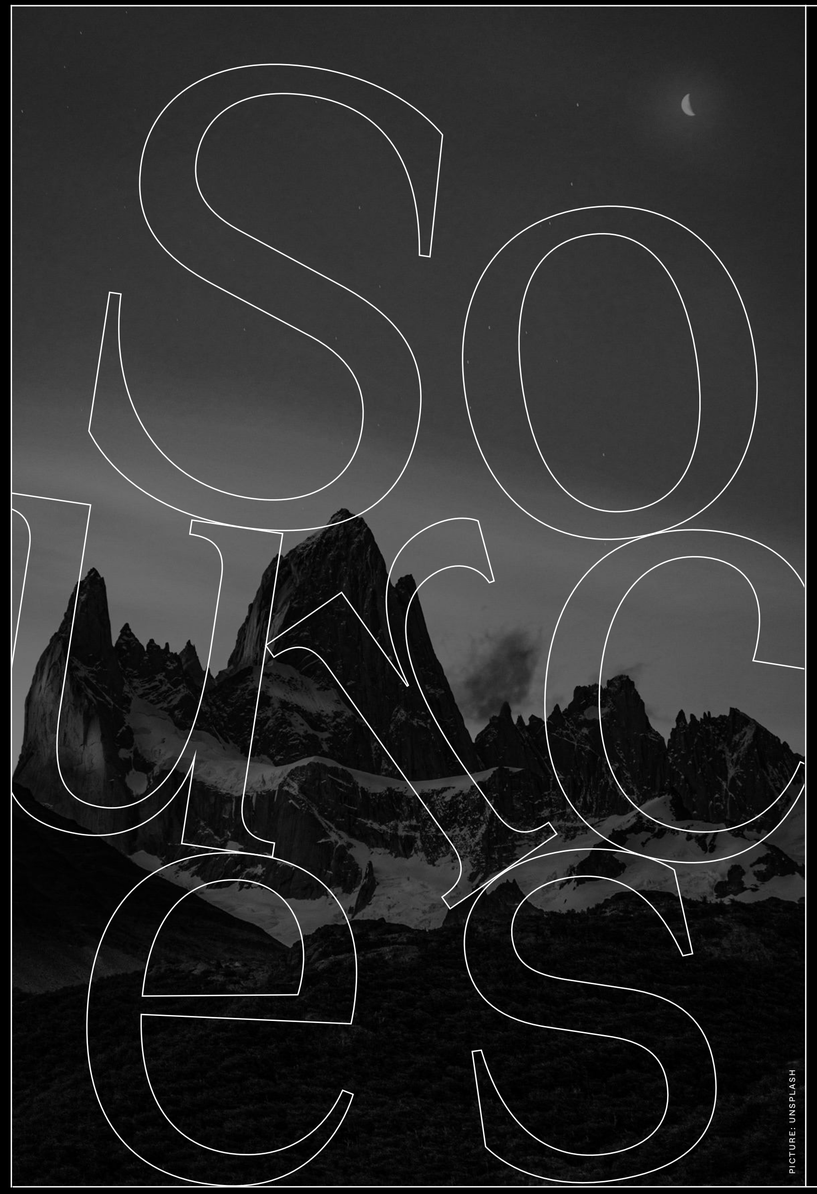
Nayture is a management consulting firm specializing in sustainable business transformations.

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PICTURE: UNSPLASH

Sources



www.patagonia.com

Patagonia doesn’t use the word ‘sustainable.’ Here’s why (via Fortune)

Pitons by Allison Albright (via American Alpine Club)

Sierra Club Announces 2018 Award Winners

Patagonia Registers as First California Benefit Corporation (via Outside)

Patagonia v. Trump (via The New York Times)

Patagonia Wins UN‘s Champions of the Earth Award in 2019 (via Business Insider)

Patagonia is ‘going purpose’ as founder gifts company to climate crisis fight (via Marketing Week)

The Size of the Company ‚Given Away‘ to Save the Planet (via Statista)

Patagonia launches cross-country mobile repair tour (via Los Angeles Times)

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